



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Covenant Classical School
School Website: <https://covenantclassicalschool.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Covenant Classical School Illinois (Naperville, 60540) presents a robust classical and Christian education model with strong alignment to the classical education rubric. Public-facing materials repeatedly emphasize classical content (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin; Certamen; Great Books/ Classics orientation; a chronological integration of studies) alongside a distinctly Christian orientation (biblical worldview, grace-filled community). The school also foregrounds communal, liturgical-style rhythm (House System; Covenant Life; Grandfriends Day; chapel-ish framing) and a clearly expressed partnership with parents (Tailored Tuition, open campus, parent involvement expectations). Taken together, the available materials strongly support a CLASSICAL rating across most dimensions, with Pedagogy showing strong classical elements but some ambiguity about explicit Socratic/seminar seminars in all grade bands. Across the six categories, Covenant demonstrates repeated evidence of traditional classical aims and practices, with full alignment in five categories and partial alignment in Pedagogy. Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL.

Key insights: - Foundational religious/philosophical framing is explicit (biblical worldview, Christian formation, grace-filled community) and paired with classical content (Latin, Certamen, grammar/logic/rhetoric). This supports Element 1 and Element 3 strongly, and Element 2 as well due to the pursuit of virtue, wisdom, and the true/good/beautiful.

- Curriculum is clearly structured around the Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric) across grade bands and includes Latin, classical history, and modules like Certamen; this aligns with Element 3 (Curriculum) as CLASSICAL.

- Pedagogy shows strong classical signatures (memory/recitation, chanting, guided discovery in lower grades; rhetoric and debate-oriented focus in upper grades), though explicit, widespread evidence of Socratic seminars across all high-school-grade levels is less visible in the public materials, resulting in a nuanced placement (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Pedagogy). - Faculty presentation emphasizes mentorship, living curriculum, and a "portrait" of teachers, aligning with CLASSICAL in Element 5. - Parents & Community is robustly engaged as co-educators, with explicit statements about parental partnership and formation, which supports CLASSICAL in Element 6.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Covenant presents itself as a classical Christian school with a Biblical worldview emphasis. A founding message notes "classical and Christian education" as a life-shaping foundation. - The school emphasizes forming students within a Christian framework and explicitly ties education to God's truth and goodness, framing learning within a grace-filled, Christian community. - Language such as "biblical worldview" and explicit Christian testimonies appear in public materials (e.g., Covenant Life content).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: truth, wisdom, biblical worldview, grace-filled, Christian, orthodoxy-related phrasing. - Truth/wisdom appear in Covenant materials (e.g., "pursuit of wisdom, truth, and understanding"). - Biblical worldview/Christian framing is explicit. - Negative indicators: None evident in public materials; no explicit relativism/neutral secular framing detected. - Negative signals

listed in the knowledge lexicon (e.g., relativism, secular humanism) do not appear as operational themes in Covenant's public copy. The lexicon is provided for rubric alignment, not evidence of negation here.

Why this rating - The school publicly anchors its mission in Christian theological commitments and a transcendent conception of truth and virtue, aligning with Transcendental moral realism and liturgical/community rhythms (e.g., communal practices, grace-filled learning). The explicit Biblical worldview and Christian formation signal strong Religious and Metaphysical foundations. CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials articulate formation and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty as real, knowable ideals. "Fostering a passionate pursuit of wisdom, truth, and understanding" is explicit. - The language emphasizes human formation and virtue, rather than purely job-preparation outcomes. The school positions education as formation in virtue and wisdom, with emphasis on classical aims. - References to a Biblical worldview and virtue formation reinforce the aim of human excellence in a classical frame.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, true/good/beautiful, classical mission, scholé/contemplation (where referenced). - Formation and wisdom/truth are explicit. - Negative indicators: None aligned with workforce-prep or 21st-century-skills framing in the public lines; the materials avoid reducing education to job training. The lexicon notes potential negative signals (e.g., workforce-prep emphasis) which are not foregrounded here.

Why this rating - The school consistently frames education as formation toward virtue and wisdom with the Real/True/Beautiful telos, aligning with CLASSICAL in School Purpose and Goal. CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is openly organized around grammar, logic, and rhetoric, i.e., the Trivium across levels. There are explicit references to Grammar School, Logic School, and Rhetoric School, and to classical languages such as Latin. - Latin, history, and classical texts are highlighted (e.g., Certamen program emphasizing Latin grammar, Roman history, Greco-Roman mythology). - The curriculum materials discuss a classical approach to history and culture, supporting a deep, liberal-arts oriented foundation rather than a strictly "social studies" framing.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin; history (Western civilization); great books/classics; primary sources; training in intellect and virtue. - Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric explicit; Latin emphasis present; Certamen content demonstrates classical content. - Negative indicators: none of the lexicon-supported negative signals appear in the public Covenant materials; no replacement of history with "social studies" framing observed; no project-based-first emphasis evident in the public copy.

Why this rating - Covenant's public materials consistently present a Trivium-centered curriculum with Latin and classical history elements and discussions around Great Books/Great Conversation through classical activities (Certamen), placing it firmly in CLASSICAL. CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower-school pedagogy features singing/music and memory-based approaches referenced in the classical lexicon, with a nod to wonder and delight in learning (e.g., "Joyful Focus on the Fundamentals" pieces which describe song/movement in foundational learning). - Upper-school pedagogy includes rhetoric and opportunities to develop oratory skills via the Rhetoric School pathway and co-curriculars (e.g., Certamen and rhetoric-oriented programming). - Some public statements emphasize direct instruction and a "grace-filled" environment, with a strong emphasis on direct teaching and high expectations, rather than an unstructured student-led approach. - There is explicit mention of a Collegiate Model Rhetoric Program (9th-12th) and a pathway to upper-level rhetoric and oratory.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: singing/recitation/memory work; contemplative/restful learning; scholé/wonder (from the classical pedagogy lexicon and Covenant materials); rhetoric, seminars, and pauses in the upper school (via the rhetoric track). - Detected elements include memory work, chanting, and rhythm in early years, as well as rhetoric-focused upper grades.

- Negative indicators present: explicit emphasis on direct instruction and structured programs, with less explicit evidence of broad, student-directed experiential learning dominating the classroom. The lexicon warns against purely experiential/project-based pedagogy; Covenant materials emphasize direct instruction and teacher-led components. - The gap: Absence of consistently documented Socratic seminars, teacher-led vs. student-led balance across all grades is not fully explicit in the public copy. This creates a partial classicality in pedagogy.

Why this rating - Covenant shows several classical pedagogy markers (memory/repetition in lower grades, singing/chanting, and a strong rhetoric/Collegiate Model in upper grades) but doesn't uniformly document Socratic seminars or full-year classical seminars across all grade levels in public materials. This yields a classification of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Pedagogy. Evidence of explicit Socratic/inquiry-based seminars is present in some high-school trajectory materials but not comprehensively across the entire public footprint. SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are described as “model teachers and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge,” and there are explicit references to the faculty forming the “living curriculum.” - The school presents a visible, robust administrative and teaching team with named leaders (Head of School; Grammar School Principal; Upper School Dean) and bios, indicating a professional, mission-aligned faculty. - The page on “Our Team” and faculty profiles emphasize a collegiate culture and a classical formation of teachers.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: living curriculum, portraits of teachers, faculty as mentors, collegial culture, ongoing professional formation. - Phrases such as “living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher” align with classical faculty indicators. - Negative indicators: none observed in public copy; no negative signals noted in the faculty sections. The lexicon lists “negative signals” but Covenant materials do not appear to adopt them (e.g., facilitators-on-the-side, over-technical jargon without classical context). - The lexicon provides the negative category as a framework, not as evidence of Covenant's approach.

Why this rating - Covenant's public materials portray a cohesive, mission-aligned, experienced faculty with a “living curriculum” ethos, supportive of CLASSICAL standing in Element 5. CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Partnership with parents is repeatedly emphasized; materials describe parents as co-teachers and primary influencers in their child's education. - The school offers parent formation opportunities (e.g., open houses, parent orientations, and family-focused events such as Grandfriends Day and House System activities) and stresses the involvement of families in school life. - There is direct language about welcoming parents into the school community and inviting regular visits and participation, as seen in “Tailored Tuition” communications and admissions materials. - The Covenant Life section shows a family-centered model including service projects and co-curriculars that encourage parent participation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental formation, open campus, family participation, community of grace. - The school explicitly frames parents as co-teachers and participants in formation. - Negative indicators: None observed; no consumer-model/customer-centric framing (which would signal negative signals in the lexicon). The materials consistently frame parent involvement as integral to the educational project. The lexicon's negative signals do not appear in Covenant's public materials.

Why this rating - Covenant demonstrates a strong, classical-aligned approach to Parents & Community with explicit parent partnership and formation, placing Element 6 at CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall ranking: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- If aiming to move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (Pedagogy) to CLASSICAL, Covenant could publish more explicit, system-wide evidence of Socratic or Paideia-style seminars and discussion-based pedagogy across more grade levels, including explicit examples of upper-level seminars and student-led inquiry. This would align Pedagogy even more strongly with the classical rubric. Additionally, making explicit references to Great Books or primary-source “Great Conversation” in the curriculum materials would fortify Element 3 and reduce ambiguity around Great Books alignment.
- Another potential needle-mover would be to foreground explicit liturgical or communal worship practices in classroom or daily routines (while maintaining the Christian orientation). This would strengthen Religious and Metaphysical Foundations by foregrounding liturgical/communal practice as a core element rather than separate events.
- More direct, public articulation of a formal teacher profile or explicit “portrait of a teacher” in all staff biographies could reinforce the Faculty category and further embed the living-curriculum approach.
- While not strictly required to reach CLASSICAL, expanding “Great Books” teaching and primary-source instruction, as well as formalizing a broader classical-language track (beyond Latin), could further strengthen Curriculum coverage in the classical sense.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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